

## **Budget Meeting Notes**

**May 10, 2022**

**Via Zoom: Location:**

<https://mps02155-org.zoom.us/j/91805560779>

7:04 Mayor Lungo-Koehn starting meeting; reading introduction

Roll call: Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Melanie McLaughlin, Mea Mustone, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn, 5 present

Sharon Hays and Paul Ruseau will be joining shortly

Presentation regarding operating budget of MPS 2023.

Supt. Edouard-Vincent: Passing it on to Asst. Supt. David Murphy

David Murphy:

[Link to presentation:](#)

I am going through the background more quickly tonight. The contextual piece is important for community members. It is an opportunity for the community to see how the district is using tax dollars. The structure adopted by SC this year is meant to be more efficient while also allowing more thoughtful discussion. When we get to the slides from last night, there will be pieces that we moved quickly through last night. We will have a comprehensive budget update at the 5.16.2022 School Committee meeting. We hope to put forth the request to the municipal government at that time. The Mayor will make a recommendation to the City Council and then the SC will be asked to take a vote to adopt that budget.

We have nine open Collective bargaining agreements which is a variable we are negotiating and a major factor in our budget process. Competitiveness and sustainability are important when it comes to collective bargaining.

Tonight our priorities are aligned with the Superintendent's strategic plan. The aspirational priorities are translated into operational objectives in our budgetary plan.

Every number is an estimation but we will continue to scrub these numbers. The subscriptions may come in under \$155K but that is still uncertain. Prior to taking a vote, all of it will be tied to various line items and you will have a more precise sense of the spending.

\$67.4M to \$71M budget from FY22 to FY23 Including FY 2% increase in wages. Conundrum is wanting to avoid structural deficits. Don't want to commit one time funding to personnel needs but we recognize that it is personnel that students require to bridge the gaps created by the pandemic. There are places where it is advantageous to use ESSER funding to bridge those

gaps. Each of those federal funding sources have eligibility criteria. Neither the city nor the schools can commit that funding to certain personnel choices.

Organizational Chart for MPS: how we are currently organized. There may be shifts going forward in order to achieve the strategic plan set forth by the Superintendent.

Using the categorization of A to F, some of the labeling might shift as we move through the budget process. Each priority is labeled in these categories. It is not a hierarchy of priorities.

We do not want the MPS students who attended during the pandemic to have had their education disrupted because of the pandemic. The budget is organized in a way to remedy this situation.

FY23 Strategic Priorities: expanding on a few points that we may not have addressed fully last night.

**Math Coaches: 2 - 4 FTE staff to support Investigations III implementation**

Making a commitment to the new elementary math curriculum. One of few priorities we feel should be in the operating budget. Category A.

**MS/HS Registrar: to support transcript requests and scheduling optimization:** exists in most districts of our size; categorized level D; it is prioritized in D because it is not a student facing position. In terms of making use of all staff and administrative time, will make a higher functioning secondary system. Priority does need to be student facing but this position has value.

Jenny Graham: On the registrar, this position was eliminated because of cuts in SY 21 - this correct?

Dave Murphy: I believe it was in that group of positions that was eliminated.

3.4 Librarians FTE: work of a school librarian has changed greatly while there is a consensus this would be a great thing for our schools, we also know that without a change to the structure and programming, merely changing the position from uncertified to certified will be diminished. Members of the committee feel strongly about these positions. It is a question of when not if. We want to assure that level of library literacy but we need to determine if this year is the year to make that change. I don't believe Ms. Laden is on the call tonight due to a scheduling conflict.

Suzanne Galusi: at the elementary level, library rotations are a bit scattered. K-2 go weekly with the sole purpose of signing our books. A more instructional component would be great. For 3-5, the logistics and scheduling would need to be worked out.

Peter Cushing: To make sure each school has a librarian, it would help build cohesive lessons. Our high school is the only one with a makerspace and it makes it a place to do more than just check out books.

Jenny Graham: I wanted to ask the admin to consider how we can move from a non functional level at the elementary level: .6 spread across four buildings is untenable. There is a whole host of missed opportunities for kids needing dedicated support at a 1.0 level looking at library best practices. Current structure is not sustainable. Progress could be meaningful. I agree there needs to be a curriculum. It cannot be homegrown strapped together by random resources in the district.

Dave Murphy: We need to look at strategic expansion of the vocational program. We need to maintain staffing commensurate with student interest which is growing. The interest may outpace our ability to staff it appropriately.

Chad Fallon: [link to slide deck](#)

This year we earned a capital skills grant of \$314,659. Perkins grant: \$64,071.

Melanie McLaughlin: How much are the promethean panels?

Chad Fallon: \$26K for 5. We use Perkins for equipment not for salaries. 71% students in the freshman class have chosen a CTE pathway. 45% of the students in MHS are in CTE pathways currently. 233 coming in for freshman rotation. Working to attract more out of district students (such as Belmont, Watertown, and Sudbury). We can offer seats to them based on availability. We have to retain the seats for our students. We are looking for two new instructors next year: one in Health Assisting and ECE Teaching Assistant (similar in pay to Kids Corner or make way for kids program). We have seen a plateau in enrollment for our Early Childhood program. This year, students have been traveling to the brooks school. The teaching assistant will be in the classroom to support the make way for kids program for freshman and sophomore students in the building.

Chad Fallon: Requests: Increases in Instructional Supplies (50K), Textbooks (\$10K for online subscriptions and textbooks) and \$15K for instructional equipment. Total: \$75K

David Murphy: Vocational school is unique from a funding perspective. We are keeping a close eye to make sure we are expanding in a responsible way. From the MSBA application, we need to make sure our facility is in line with our students' needs.

Melanie McLaughlin: Does the ECE have an opportunity to expand to our other elementary schools?

Chad Fallon: Brooks has been our pilot school. I now have the schools asking how we can make it a permanent thing. I envision adding two more elementary schools next year. We only

have three students as freshmen who have chosen it for sophomore year. We do have a good number of juniors and seniors enrolled.

Melanie McLaughlin: It would be interesting to expose the students to early intervention opportunities.

Kathy Kreatz: I went to the open house and was amazed by all the new great things happening there. I am happy to hear about the increased enrollment.

Peter Cushing: The regional schools are extremely competitive to get into and Medford having this facility is fantastic. We are constantly looking at ways of bringing in new programs and students. The faculty at the vocational school really sell their programs and get the kids excited. The staff are working extremely hard to make sure that the students see the value. The long term career potential

Supt. Edouard-Vincent: thanks to Mr. Fallon for his presentation. It is very exciting what is happening at the vocational school. The robotics team is traveling to CA to compete. Shows the strength of the programs at MVTHS.

Dave Murphy: We have high ambitions for the organization and for our students but need to put forth responsible requests putting forth a thoughtful rationale for the number we request of our city government. We want to maximize the public's investment in our organization. We know there are other positions in other disciplines we will need to consider in the years ahead.

Desk equipment: \$2500 not \$25000. Was a typo in last night's meeting.

Dave Murphy; the full tally of the categories will affect our numbers; the \$75k for the CTE supplies will not affect it greatly. Secondary level, ripple effect in the way the schedules operate.

Ms. Galusi will speak about the enrollment trends. We want to avoid mad dash to open additional strands right before we open in September.

Suzanne Galusi: Current enrollment slide/possible strand consolidation.

The Brooks has three MEEP programs, Roberts two, other schools one. These are the numbers right now. We are constantly getting new registrations and I am in constant contact with Paul Teixeira about his newcomer registrations.

We will keep a close eye on the missituk first grade (grade 2 next year). By consolidating it, it would not give us any wiggle room.

Mayor Lungo-Koehn: I don't remember starting this low at the beginning of the year last year? Is it people moving out of the district?

Suzanne Galusi: We started on the low end this year but we were still in active covid protocols trying to ensure as much spacing as we could.

Dave Murphy: We did have ballooning classrooms elsewhere in the district. One assumption our priorities rests on is the continuation of the progression towards normalcy.

Melanie McLaughlin: What did you say about the MEEP classrooms? I heard there is a substantial waiting list for the integrated classrooms.

Suzanne Galusi: the previous screen reflected general education classroom enrollment K-4 but didn't reflect the MEEP numbers.

Melanie McLaughlin: The numbers were absent newcomers, Special Education and EL?

Suzanne: Yes. The consolidation doesn't affect those populations.

Melanie: There will be another opportunity to ask about the MEEP program?

Dave Murphy: Yes

Suzanne Galusi: We would like to continue our partnership with Hill for Literacy. It has been a valuable partnership. I worked with Eleni Steadman to plan for next year. Goal around leadership, instruction, pd and assessment. We are continuing with ECRI. New staff will receive full training. We are expanding to include grade three staff to make sure they are versed in the terminology. For our title one and EL staff, they will be brought into the pd next year. Grounded in the science of reading pedagogy. The Dept. of Education is building an MTEL to make sure new teachers are versed in this method of teaching.

We would like Hill to assist us with our core curriculum review process. Dr. Chiesa and I will be presenting on that in the future.

Dave Murphy: This has not been articulated in a specific number yet. Some of these ongoing discussions will be included in the request but we are finalizing the specifics of whether it belongs under ESSER or the operating budget. It will be a critical priority.

Responsive Classroom: we are at the phase of offering ongoing PD at staff meetings and district level. They are finishing this month on leadership and language. Next level will be a lead teacher role to offer support and assistance to sustaining PD in responsive classroom to our teachers. This teacher will need to maintain their own credentials with responsive classroom. This would be very beneficial to our commitment to RC.

Dave Murphy: Staying on the topic of professional learning, I am going to ask PC to talk out secondary and district wide opportunities with PD. Students will be returning on the Wednesday

rather than Tuesday because the teachers will have a day of PD at the start of the school year (week before labor day).

Peter Cushing: Dibels Tier two and three for Literacy at the elementary level as well as Turks Investigations III. Turk will be here assisting our educators. Looking at training 30 educators at middle school level in Responsive Classroom so that rising grade 5 students will be able to continue with it. High School and middle school staff will be working on restorative justice as part of the hate crimes grant. November PD day will remain for DEI and Curriculum and SEL work. Critical to bring staff together early in the school year. In partnership with our teachers association, our PD group put out a survey to staff and will take a look at the results to build our programs especially in SEL. Classroom practices that support students who have been traumatized in the last two years.

Jenny Graham: Ms. Galusi, I am surprised we are investing in DIBELS? Is it based on the science of reading?

Suzanne Galusi: Tier 2 and 3 is not for classroom teachers. Teachers were using F and Ps and DRAs which really are not best practice. Using DIBELS with tier two is aligned with HILL for literacy.

Jenny Graham: Have we officially outlawed the use of tools that are not working?

Suzanne Galusi: Teachers are aware that we need to be moving away from DRA and Fountas and Pinnell as they are not aligned with Science of Reading.

Melanie McLaughlin: For members of the public, this sounds like a foreign language: professional development....these are assessment tools for reading.

Suzanne Galusi: Previously for K-3, teachers gave DRAs developmental reading assessments. Grades 4 and 5 used Fountas and Pinnell. These are no longer considered appropriate by the Dept of Education. DIBELS will do that better as there is phonemic awareness and comprehension built in.

Peter Cushing: Dibels: category C; DEI: category C; Investigations Math: Category A

Dave Murphy: Subscription and platform renewals: fixed costs: we are projecting \$155K but I am hoping we can scrub it and get it down a little bit. Every dollar counts so if we are able to pull costs down, we are eager to do it. Some costs were charged to ESSER as part of pandemic recovery.

Operations - Buildings/Grounds: Gas and electricity rising. Overtime budget: was increased in FY 22 by \$15K. Currently \$67K over budget. We are not recommending an increase on this line in the future. We will identify efficiencies on this in FY23. We are looking to have vendor agreements working with the Procurement Office to see some savings.

Buildings and Grounds Priorities: Some will go under capital repairs. I would like to present the capital priorities at a June meeting (McGlynn Classroom leak repair, high school restrooms, MHS generator, breezeway flooring in MHS). There are some issues we need to address to make sure the building is meeting safety standards. The deteriorating floor in the breezeway is one of these issues.

Based on the fluctuations between what will be addressed on the capital budget vs. the ESSER funding, what we present on Monday will be inclusive of all the priorities. I hope to convene by the end of next week so the mayor can make that request to the municipal government.

Jenny Graham: Before we talk about this again, could you please update the slide to reflect the spending by category. When we think about what we send up through our request, I would like to spend time thinking about all the categories. I don't want to just think about A and B. How do we make sure those things don't get left on the cutting room floor without a lot of thought.

Dave Murphy: My next version will reflect that. As I scrub things, the actual figures might change but they will all be available. It is a matter of how we maximize the value in the context of anything else. Nothing in here is a bad idea. You will see all the variations next time.

Jenny Graham: For example, the Elementary Librarians will not succeed without the right supports.

Melanie McLaughlin: I am looking for clarification of what is expected for next week? It would be helpful to have it laid out a bit more. Previously the department heads would come with their budgets from the previous year and what they need for the year ahead. This time, it spells out new expenditures that are aligned with the strategic plan but it doesn't show the comparison basis. For the community and for members, what does that look like for us in terms of comparison?

Dave Murphy: The budget book you receive next week will look like your previous budget book and will have the line items that allow you to compare and contrast. My hope is that we can give the school all of the competing recommendations and put forth a request that is most reflective of student needs. It is unusual for the superintendent's recommendation to be preceded by testimony of so many directors. The goal is to present more coherent information and less siloing. We are trying to retain transparency with added emphasis on coherency. The variable is on Category B (things we have to do on the basis of compliance but which fund to use).

Melanie McLaughlin: Is the expectation that we will be voting on a number for next Monday's meeting?

Dave Murphy: It doesn't have to be Monday but there may be more deliberation.

Melanie McLaughlin: When will we get the budget books?

Dave Murphy: The public should be able to comment on it prior to the vote. Monday will be that opportunity. We will send them the draft to you electronically next week.

Sharon Hays: We got sent a spreadsheet from principals and administrators: how do those requests fit into this presentation?

Dave Murphy: Those will be in the budget book. The spreadsheet shows what the admin. Team have been looking at to build priorities. Policy objective is not for the SC to be voting on individual principal/director priorities.

Sharon Hays; I didn't hear anything about any of those supports (math coaches).

Dave Murphy: All have been referenced in the priority list in the personnel chart.

Jenny Graham: This is my third budget and when I started there was a silent understanding that the administration was never going to ask more than what the mayor would want to provide. This process looks different and we are finally getting to an alignment of our strategic plan guiding priorities and determining how we identify priorities. Hearing what the directors are doing year to year in their departments was less helpful than this way of telling the community of what MPS needs to allow students to reach their full potential while recognizing that there are other variables in play. We are making process on a better, more transparent process that is more aligned to the strategic plan. It is always important to hear from those doing the work without subjecting them to hours of these meetings. Change is good.

Dave Murphy: Last year the delta was \$764K. Our initial request included the math coaches which we knew we needed but it may have been premature. After purchasing the math curriculum, it will be the better time to bring on additional FTEs.

Melanie: Motion to adjourn the meeting.

Kathy Kreatz: Second the motion.

Mea Mustone called the roll: Jenny Graham, Sharon Hays, Kathy Kreatz, Mea Mustone, Melanie McLaughlin, Mayor Lungo-Koehn: 6/1 (Paul Ruseau stepped away).  
Meeting adjourned at 9:20PM.

